

One FPL truth, not two

Why a simple rule can beat a model and still lose to a skilled human

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The headlines look opposite

40-START STRATEGY SIM

+159 simple rule
vs model

The model also beat hold by 199.

45-WINDOW TRANSFER REPLAY

+197 human buys
vs simple rule

The rule still beat holding by 53.

The signs differ because the opponents differ.

159 is a simulated-season mean. 197 is a summed replay gap.

The opponent changed

NOTEBOOK QUESTION

**Can the rule beat
a model and no transfers?**

Yes, in the 40-start strategy simulation.

REPLAY QUESTION

**Can the rule beat
the manager's actual
buys?**

No, on the 45 scored transfer windows.

**Different opponents can produce different winners without
contradiction.**

Human judgment tops this replay

One common metric ranks human > rule > hold. The model tie comes from another experiment.

SKILLED HUMAN > SIMPLE RULE $\approx$ MODEL* > NOTHING



*Model was not replay-scored. Its transfer tie is separate. Never compare the 159 and 197 gaps.

Same rule, different opponents

The rule wins against the model and hold, then loses against the skilled human.

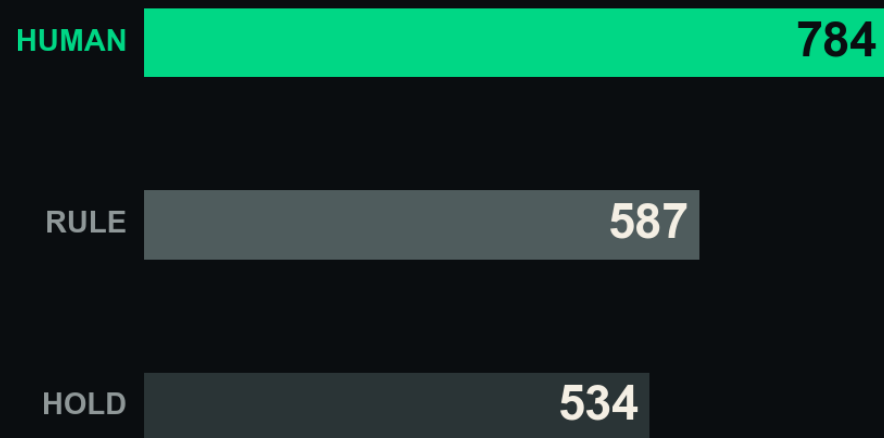
40-START STRATEGY SIM



Mean GW8-34 points across 40 starts

Rule beats model by 159

45-WINDOW TRANSFER REPLAY



Incoming or held points in fixed windows

Rule trails human by 197

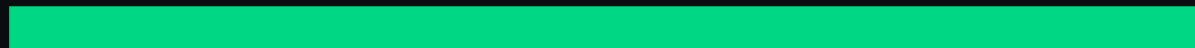
159 and 197 are different currencies. Compare direction, never magnitude.

159 and 197 use different metrics. Compare direction, never magnitude.

Both studies find a weak signal

Different targets tell the same story: form adds little once availability is handled.

NOTEBOOK: form → next-4 points



+0.20

REPLAY STUDY: form → next-4 goals



+0.19

SAME FAILURE MODE

Safe model misses big captain hauls

Captaincy: model -23 points vs rule

Rule blocks 11 of 46 human buys

Injury returns and role judgment sit outside the filter

Both miss upside when a mechanical availability view is too safe.

The 159 simulation gap and 197 replay gap use different metrics.

159 and 197 use different metrics. Compare direction, never magnitude.

The rule is a floor, not a ceiling

SKILLED HUMAN > SIMPLE RULE ~ MODEL > NOTHING

FLOOR

Rule beats passivity

Cheap, clear, repeatable

CEILING

Judgment finds upside

Role changes, news, packages

Use the rule to narrow the field. Use judgment to make the call.

Use the rule, then add judgment

- 1 Filter availability** Starts, recent minutes, injury news, likely role
- 2 Build the shortlist** Recent points as context, plus xGI, fixtures, price
- 3 Review the package** Bank, cash released, hits, squad structure
- 4 Make the upside call** Role change, captain ceiling, reasons to break the rule

Only promote a new model when it beats this rule on decision points.

Keep the two currencies apart

159

40-start simulated-season mean gap

197

45-window summed transfer-replay gap

- 1 One manager and one season. Luck can shape the replay gap.
- 2 Replay points ignore XI use, captaincy, benching, and transfer hits.
- 3 Eleven of 46 human buys failed at least one locked rule filter.
- 4 The notebook hold baseline means no transfers, with Engine selection and captaincy.
- 5 The model has no complete clean replay score, so its placement stays qualitative.

Keep the floor. Hunt the ceiling.

The simple rule protects against passivity.

Skilled judgment adds role, context, and upside.

Different opponents. One unified truth.

Never compare the 159 and 197 gaps as magnitudes.